

Year 5 Reading Comprehension - Secret of the Reef

Name: _____ Date: _____

ACARA v9.0: AC9E5LY05 - use comprehension strategies to analyse information, ideas and literal and inferred meaning in texts.

Learning Intention

I can infer character feelings and explain how setting details contribute to meaning.

Reading Strategy

Track clues about the setting, character actions and dialogue to build an inference.

Vocabulary Helper

survey: a careful check or study

bleaching: when coral loses colour because of stress

lagoon: a shallow sea area protected by reef or land

observe: to watch carefully and notice details

Before You Read

Think about how a beautiful place can also need careful protection.

The Secret of the Reef Survey

Ari pressed his mask against his face and looked down into the clear lagoon. Beneath him, the reef was a maze of coral branches, silver fish and waving sea grass. His aunty, a marine scientist, floated nearby with a waterproof clipboard.

Today was Ari's first reef survey. He had expected it to feel like an adventure, and it did, but there was something serious in Aunty Leila's voice when she explained the task. They were not just counting fish. They were checking whether parts of the reef were healthy, damaged or beginning to bleach.

Ari noticed a patch of coral that looked pale, almost like bone. He pointed, and Aunty Leila nodded slowly. Later, on the boat, she showed him how to record the location. Ari felt a twist in his stomach. The reef was beautiful, but it was also vulnerable.

That night, Ari wrote in his notebook: Observing means more than seeing. It means noticing what needs care. He decided that the secret of the reef was not hidden treasure. It was responsibility.

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Questions and written response

Warm Up

Circle the genre: realistic fiction / report / poem. Then write one clue that helped you decide.

Build Your Skills

1. Who is Aunty Leila and what is her role?

2. Why does the survey feel serious as well as adventurous?

3. What does Ari notice about one patch of coral?

4. What can you infer about Ari's feelings on the boat?

5. How does the reef setting help the reader understand the message?

6. Explain the meaning of Ari's final notebook sentence.

Strong Challenge

Write a diary entry from Ari's point of view after the survey. Include one setting detail and one feeling.

I Can

- ☐ I read carefully.
- ☐ I used evidence.
- ☐ I explained my thinking.

High Five!

Excellent inference work! You used clues from setting and character actions.

Teacher Feedback

Strength: _____

Next: _____

Secret of the Reef - Answer Key

For teachers, parents and tutors

Detailed Answers

1. Aunty Leila is Ari's aunty and a marine scientist leading the survey.
2. It is an adventure because Ari explores the reef, but serious because they check for damage and bleaching.
3. He notices pale coral that looks almost like bone.
4. He may feel worried, sad or concerned because the text says he felt a twist in his stomach.
5. The beautiful but vulnerable reef shows why careful observation and care matter.
6. Ari realises that observing is not only about seeing details; it can lead to responsibility and care.

Success Guide

Strong inferences use text clues such as the pale coral, serious voice and twist in Ari's stomach.

Parent Tip - At Home

Ask your child to find three words that create the reef setting. Then ask: How do these words make the place feel?

Teacher Tip - In Class

Create an inference chart: clue / what I infer / why. Model with Ari's stomach feeling before students answer independently.

Extension Idea

Write three questions Ari could ask Aunty Leila before the next survey.